

Recipes for color, texture, and scent

STEM INTEREST IN A SPRING BORDER

Few plants surpass the Himalayan birch for year-round stem interest. Set the tree's startling white trunks against a dark backdrop to produce the most eye-catching effect and choose a multistemmed form to increase the impact. Underplant the tree with shade-tolerant alliums, cranesbills, lady's mantle, and ferns to provide color and texture through spring and summer. These plants also cope with the well-drained soil conditions beneath a tree. In early spring, apply a mulch of well-rotted organic matter, such as shredded leaves.

Plant list

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| 1 <i>Alchemilla mollis</i> | 4 <i>Allium</i> 'Purple Sensation' |
| 2 <i>Geranium himalayense</i> | 5 <i>Geranium clarkei</i> |
| 'Gravetye' | 'Kashmir White' |
| 3 <i>Galega</i> hybrid | 6 <i>Betula utilis</i> var. <i>jacquemontii</i> |

